

Adults 50+ Aren’t Behind on AI. The Classes Are.

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Adults 50+ Aren't Behind on AI. The Classes Are.

AARP's own 2026 data says most adults over 50 have already used AI. They just don't feel they can. That is not a learner problem. It is a program problem.

I have watched it happen in a library chair.

Someone sits down who has been told — by ads, by their kids, sometimes by the class title on the flyer — that they are catching up. They have a smartphone. They have used the little AI box that pops up when they search. They have heard ChatGPT on the news. Then the session starts with a lecture about what artificial intelligence *is*, and you can feel the room shrink.

They did not come to be told they are late.

They came to ask a real question and leave with something in their hands.

They have used it. They do not feel fluent.

AARP's 2026 research on how adults 50+ view AI is the number that should end the “have they heard of it?” debate.

Only 5% say they have never heard of AI. About eight in ten have used some form of it. Most still call themselves beginners. Only 8% feel knowledgeable enough to explain it to someone else. Nearly a quarter have never used it at all.

That is not a population that needs another awareness campaign. That is a population that tried the tool once, did not trust the answer, and did not know the next sentence to type without looking foolish.

The same research is honest about the fear. Most adults 50+ think AI is moving faster than the rules. They worry it will replace conversation. Half think it is insecure. Four in ten do not trust it to be accurate.

So of course they hesitate. The programs built for them often confirm the hesitation. They talk *about* AI. They do not open it.

A 2025 study of adults 50+ found the same two barriers, over and over: *I don't understand it* and *I don't know where to start*. They also said, clearly, that they want hands-on learning — not a slideshow.

EY's 2026 work on older generations and AI said the preferred help is simple: easy guides, in places they already trust. Libraries. Community centers. Rooms with a familiar parking lot.

If your AI class never opens ChatGPT, it is not a class. It is a TED Talk.

The wrong name is the real curriculum

Most 50+ technology education still runs on deficit language.

Senior tech help. Digital immigrant. Left behind. Catching up.

Tell a 70-year-old she is catching up and she feels a hole. Tell her she is a Digital Pioneer and she sits up. That is not branding fluff. It is pedagogy. People learn faster when the label does not insult the decades they already survived.

I am 65. I built the first of these sessions from a folding table in a public library. I spent years in community development, including a stretch as an AARP community development manager in Austin. I have seen the event model — collect the email, fill the room, hope the offer matches the moment. Sometimes it does not.

What worked was simpler. Meet people where they already eat lunch, already wait for bingo, already trust the librarian. Put the tool on the screen. Let them type a question they actually care about.

At one Austin Public Library session, a woman who was 72 used AI for the first time. She had been telling herself for five years she was too old. She asked about a medication. She looked up and said the answer explained something her doctor had never taken the time to explain.

That is the job. Not a certificate on the wall. A useful sentence, today.

We do this work as Learn More Technologies, through 50+TechBridge, across 9 in-person locations in Central Texas — including 6 Austin Public Library branches, AARP-affiliated senior centers, and a Foundation Communities veterans program. The curriculum is WIOA-eligible. We are MBE-certified. The City of Austin funded part of the proof through a Nexus grant.

AARP and Senior Planet already run large, free class catalogs, including AI lectures. Good. The country needs that scale. What they do not sell — and what most library one-offs do not name — is a repeatable method you can finish in one sitting, an identity that is not “remedial,” and a path for the workforce board or the employer sitting in the back of the room.

We do not claim to be the only 50+ AI program in America. We claim to have a method.

Five steps. One prompt. Then you save it.

Every session, regardless of the room, runs the same five steps.

1. Open. Open ChatGPT or another approved tool. No prior experience. The blank screen is the first barrier. We walk through it.

2. Ask. Use a starter prompt that tells the tool who you are and how you want the answer:

I'm new to AI and I'm over 50. Please explain [topic] in five simple steps, using clear language.

That sentence is free. Steal it. It is the difference between a wall of jargon and five steps you can actually try.

3. Read. Look for one useful thing. Not perfection. Not a medical degree. One useful thing.

4. Follow up. Ask a second question. This is the skill most first-timers skip. A search box is a vending machine. A follow-up is a conversation.

5. Save. Screenshot. Copy. Handwritten note. The session is not over until something leaves the room in their pocket.

Start with a task they already have: a Medicare letter, a message to a grandchild, a resume after a layoff, a trip they want to take. Abstract definitions come later, if they come at all.

You can keep going at home in the same spirit. Ask Barb, our in-browser guide, is built for that — plain talk on health, money, staying connected, safety, and the fun stuff. In a classroom we also practice with the same kind of AI people will see at chatgpt.com. The point is not which logo is on the screen. The point is that the tutorial matches real life.

The one rule that is not optional

AI can be wrong.

Especially about medicine, law, and money. The human decides. Verify before you act.

That rule is not a footnote. It is in the first fifteen minutes, because 2025 made the cost of skipping it impossible to ignore.

Americans reported \$20.9 billion in internet-crime losses last year. Adults 60 and older reported \$7.7 billion stolen — the highest of any age group, and about 60% more than the year before, according to the FBI's numbers as reported by AARP. The FTC found people 50+ reported \$4.3 billion lost to fraud. The FBI tied \$352 million in older-adult losses to AI-related scams: voice clones, deepfakes, the “family in distress” call that sounds like someone you love.

The answer is not “avoid AI.” Scammers will not avoid it. The answer is to learn the tool in a room you already trust, with a habit: if it is medicine, law, or money — or a voice on the phone asking you to send cash — you pause and check.

Fear-only programs train people to see themselves as victims. Pioneer programs train operators who know when to close the laptop and call the real grandchild.

This is not charity. It is the economy.

AARP's 2026 Longevity Economy Outlook is the other number people in the back of the room need.

Adults 50+ generated \$12.5 trillion in U.S. GDP in 2024 — 43% of the economy, large enough to be the third-largest on earth if it were a country. They account for 56% of household spending. They pay

nearly 60% of federal income taxes. By 2060 that footprint is projected at \$24 trillion.

Leaving this group out of AI is not kindness. London School of Economics research with Protiviti put the cost of an untrained 50+ worker at about \$18,000 a year in lost productivity and friction. AARP and Oxford Economics estimated the annual cost of ageism in the United States at \$850 billion.

Workforce boards already have a federal path. WIOA dollars exist to train adult workers, including people 50+ navigating the digital economy. Employers who treat their most experienced people as a write-off are paying that tax whether they see the line item or not.

Brands that still write copy as if the only customer who matters is 28 are leaving the actual spending sitting in the parking lot.

Two customers. One proof.

The person in the library chair gets a name, a method, and a saved answer. The organization that serves, employs, or sells to that person gets something they can deploy — on-site or online — without inventing a curriculum from a slide deck.

You are not behind. The offer was.

If you are 50+ and you have been waiting for permission: open the tool. Paste the starter prompt. Ask about the thing on your kitchen table. Read it. Ask one more question. Save what is useful. Check anything that touches your health, your money, or the law.

If you run a library, a workforce board, a senior center, or a company with a 50+ team: stop buying lectures that never touch the keyboard. Put the session in the room people already trust. Call them Pioneers. Measure the work by whether someone leaves with a page in their pocket, not by how many slides you clicked.

50+TechBridge is built for both of those people. Come sit in a session. Or ask us what a deployment looks like in your building.

The technology is not the hard part.

The hard part was the name we were given.

We changed it.

LinkedIn post

Author: Brian McKinney | **Hashtags:** #FutureOfWork #WorkforceDevelopment #AILiteracy #AGENTIC50 #50PlusTechBridge

AARP's 2026 data says 8 in 10 adults 50+ have already used AI.

Only 8% feel they could explain it to someone else.

The problem isn't awareness. Every program still treats them like they're late.

I'm 65. I built the first of these sessions on a folding table in a public library.

Someone sits down who already has a smartphone, who already uses the little AI box that pops up when they search. Then the class opens with a lecture on what artificial intelligence is — and you can feel the room shrink.

They didn't come to be told they're behind. They came to ask a real question and leave with something in their hands.

At an Austin Public Library branch, a woman of 72 used AI for the first time. She asked about a medication. She looked up and said the answer explained something her doctor had never taken the time to explain.

That's the job. Not a certificate on the wall. A useful sentence, today.

What actually works:

- Open the tool. Don't describe it.
- Start with a task they already have — a Medicare letter, a resume after a layoff.
- Teach the follow-up question. A search box is a vending machine. A follow-up is a conversation.
- Save something before they leave. Screenshot, copy, handwritten note.
- First fifteen minutes, one rule: medicine, law, money — the human verifies before acting.

If your AI class never opens the tool, it isn't a class. It's a TED Talk.

We run this as 50+TechBridge across 9 in-person locations in Central Texas, including 6 Austin

Public Library branches. The curriculum is WIOA-eligible. We're MBE-certified.

We call the people in those chairs Pioneers. That isn't branding. It's pedagogy.

What would change if your 50+ workforce were called Pioneers instead of a training problem?

OPS NOTES (NOT FOR POSTING)

Post Tue/Wed 7:45–8:30 AM CT. First comment: drop the starter prompt as a giveaway. Reply to every comment in the first hour. No link in the post body.

Newsletter

Subject: You're not behind. The class was.

Preview: The 5-step method, the Starter Prompt, and the one rule we never skip.

A woman sat down beside me at an Austin library branch and told me she was too old for this.

She was 72. She'd been telling herself that for five years.

Ten minutes later she typed a question about one of her medications. She read the answer, looked up, and said it explained something no one had taken the time to explain to her.

She wasn't behind. She'd just never been handed the keyboard.

Here's what I keep running into.

Most adults over 50 have already used AI in some form. Only about 5% say they've never heard of it.

But only 8% feel they could explain it to someone else.

That gap isn't a learner problem. It's a program problem.

Too many "senior tech" classes spend an hour talking about AI and never open it. If the class never opens the tool, it isn't a class. It's a TED Talk.

So we run every session the same five steps.

1. Open. Open the tool. The blank screen is the first barrier, so we walk through it together.

2. Ask. Use the Starter Prompt. This one is yours — steal it:

I'm new to AI and I'm over 50. Please explain [topic] in five simple steps, using clear language.

3. Read. Look for one useful thing. Not perfection. One useful thing.

4. Follow up. Ask a second question. A search box is a vending machine. A follow-up is a conversation.

5. Save. Screenshot it. Copy it. Write it down. The session isn't over until something leaves the room in your pocket.

Start with a task already on your kitchen table — a Medicare letter, a note to a grandchild, a resume, a trip you want to take.

And one rule that is never optional.

AI can be wrong. Especially about medicine, law, and money.

The human decides. Verify before you act.

That rule isn't a footnote. It's in our first fifteen minutes, every single time.

Hit reply and tell me one thing: what's the first question you'd type into AI if you knew nobody was watching?

I read every response. Some of them become next month's session.

I'm 65. I built the first of these from a folding table in a public library, and we now run them across 9 in-person locations in Central Texas, including 6 Austin Public Library branches.

The technology was never the hard part. The hard part was the name we were given.

We changed it.

— Brian

Brian McKinney

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OPS NOTES (NOT FOR SENDING)

Send Tue/Thu 7:00–8:00 AM. One CTA only (reply). Session invite goes to people who reply, in a later email. A/B subjects: “What would you ask AI if nobody watched?” / “She was 72 and said she was too old”

X thread

Tweet 1

If your AI class never opens ChatGPT, it isn't a class. It's a TED Talk.

AARP's own research: about 8 in 10 adults 50+ have already used AI.

They don't need awareness. They need someone to open the tool. (thread)

Tweet 2

Here's the starter prompt we hand out in every session. Steal it:

"I'm new to AI and I'm over 50. Please explain [topic] in five simple steps, using clear language."

That sentence is the difference between a wall of jargon and five steps you can actually try.

Tweet 3

2025, per the FBI: adults 60+ reported \$7.7B stolen online. \$352M of older-adult losses were tied to AI scams — voice clones, deepfakes, the "grandchild in trouble" call.

The answer isn't avoid AI. Scammers won't avoid it.

Learn it in a room you already trust.

Tweet 4

Five steps. One sitting.

Open. Ask. Read. Follow up. Save.

A search box is a vending machine. A follow-up question is a conversation.

The session isn't over until something leaves the room in somebody's pocket.

Tweet 5

Tell a 70-year-old she's catching up and she feels a hole. Tell her she's a Digital Pioneer and she sits up.

That's not branding. That's pedagogy.

You are not behind. The offer was.

What's the first thing you'd ask AI if nobody was watching?

LinkedIn micro-post

If your AI class never opens ChatGPT, it isn't a class. It's a TED Talk.

AARP's research says about 8 in 10 adults 50+ have already used AI. They're not behind. The offer was.

Steal our starter prompt: "I'm new to AI and I'm over 50. Please explain [topic] in five simple steps, using clear language."

If you run a library, a workforce board, or a team with 50+ talent on it — stop buying lectures that never touch the keyboard.

What would you ask first?

Podcast Q&A 1 — Isn't AARP already doing this?

Q: Okay, let me ask you the blunt one. AARP runs free classes. Senior Planet runs free classes. Both of them have AI on the calendar right now. So — isn't AARP already doing this?

Good. Ask me that one, because I used to work there. I spent a stretch as an AARP community development manager in Austin, and I'll say this first: they should be doing it, and I'm glad they are. The country needs that scale. Senior Planet, too. Free, national, enormous reach. I'm not here to run those down, and let me be clear about something else — we do not claim to be the only 50+ AI program in America. That would be a lie and it wouldn't help anybody.

Here's the difference, though. What they sell is a catalog. A catalog of lectures. You can scroll a beautiful list of sessions about what artificial intelligence *is* — the history, the ethics, the concerns. All of that is real. But you can sit through every one of them and never once put your hands on the tool.

And that's the thing. I've watched this in a library chair. Somebody sits down, they've got a smartphone in their purse, they've seen the little AI box pop up when they search, they've heard ChatGPT on the news — and then the session opens with a definition. You can feel the room shrink.

They didn't come to be told they're late. They came to ask a real question and leave with something in their hands.

So what we do is a method, not a catalog. Three pieces. One — the tool actually gets opened. ChatGPT is on the screen in a library they already drive to, in a parking lot they already know. We're in nine in-person locations across Central Texas, six of them Austin Public Library branches. Two — the name. We don't call anybody a senior needing tech help, we don't say digital immigrant, we don't say catching up. We call them Digital Pioneers. And people think that's a marketing decision. It's not. It's pedagogy. Tell a 70-year-old she's behind and she feels a hole open up. Tell her she's a Pioneer and she sits up in the chair. She learns faster. I've watched it happen in the same hour.

And three — and this is the one nobody else names — there's a way to pay for it. Our curriculum is WIOA-eligible. That means a workforce board can fund this as adult worker training. It's not a donation. It's not charity. It's a line item that already exists in federal law.

So bottom line: catalogs of lectures are good, and we need them. But a lecture doesn't put the tool in somebody's hands. We do that, we give them a name they'll repeat out loud, and we hand the workforce board a way to write the check.

Podcast Q&A 2 — Why “behind” bothers you

Q: So I've been wondering about the framing on all of this. Everybody talks about getting older adults caught up on AI. You push back on the word “behind.” Why does that word bother you so much?

Because it's not true, and because it's expensive.

Start with the not-true part. AARP's own research says about eight in ten adults over 50 have already used AI in some form. Only a sliver have never even heard of it. So the awareness campaign is over. We won that one. What's actually happening is people have used it, didn't trust the answer, and didn't know the next sentence to type without feeling foolish. That's not a learner problem. That is a program problem. They are not behind. The offer was.

And here's where it gets interesting — the same research tells you exactly what they want. Hands-on. Easy guides. In places they already trust. That's it. That's the whole ask. Libraries, community centers, a room with a familiar parking lot. Nobody said “please give me another slideshow about the history of machine learning.”

Now the expensive part. When you tell somebody they're behind, they act like it. They hesitate. They don't open the thing. And the people who are not hesitating — I'll tell you who's not hesitating — are the scammers. The FBI's 2025 numbers, as AARP reported them: adults 60 and older lost \$7.7 billion. Highest of any age group. And \$352 million of older-adult losses were tied specifically to AI-related scams. Voice clones. Deepfakes. The family-in-distress call that sounds exactly like somebody you love.

So people hear that and they say, well, then stay away from AI. No. That's backwards. Scammers are not going to avoid it. If you've never heard a synthetic voice in a room where it's safe, the first one you hear will be the one asking you to wire money. Fear-only programs train people to see themselves as victims. Pioneer programs train operators — people who know when to close the laptop and call the real grandchild.

Think about it this way. Adults 50 and up generated twelve and a half trillion dollars of U.S. GDP in 2024, per AARP's Longevity Economy Outlook. Forty-three percent of the economy. That is not a group that needs to catch up to anything. That's the group holding the thing up.

So when I hear “behind,” I don't hear a description. I hear a product that was built wrong. We changed the name. The technology was never the hard part.

Podcast Q&A 3 — What a 62-year-old should do at home

Q: Alright, somebody's listening to this in the car right now and they're 62 and they've never typed a word into one of these things. What do you want them to do the second they get home?

Open it. That's step one and it's the hardest one. ChatGPT, or whatever approved tool you've got. The blank screen is the real barrier — not the technology, the blank screen. Nobody tells you what to put in it.

So here's what you put in it. I'm going to give you the whole thing, free, right now. You type: *I'm new to AI and I'm over 50. Please explain* — and then whatever your thing is — *in five simple steps, using clear language.*

That's it. That's the starter prompt. Steal it. Write it on an index card and tape it to the monitor. What it does is it tells the tool who you are and how you want the answer, and that one sentence is the difference between a wall of jargon and five steps you can actually try tonight.

And don't start with something abstract. Don't ask it what artificial intelligence is. Start with the thing already sitting on your kitchen table. The Medicare letter you don't understand. A message to a grandchild you can't find the words for. A resume, if there was a layoff. A trip you've been wanting to take.

Then three more steps. Read it — and look for *one* useful thing. Not perfection. Not a medical degree. One useful thing. Then follow up. Ask a second question. This is the step everybody skips and it's the whole skill. A search box is a vending machine. A follow-up is a conversation. And then save it. Screenshot it, copy it, write it on paper — I don't care. The session isn't over until something leaves the room in your pocket.

One rule, and it's not optional. AI can be wrong. Especially about medicine, law, and money. The human decides. So if it touches your health, your money, or the law — or it's a voice on the phone asking you to send cash — you pause and you check. Every time.

That's the whole method. Open, ask, read, follow up, save. You can do it before dinner.